From UX Design to Counselling Psychology

A 9-month self-learning roadmap · prepared October 2026 · focus: workplace counselling & digital-age wellbeing

> **Your profile:** B.E. Mechanical · UX designer (~₹8 LPA) · HFI Certified Usability Analyst · age 28 · India.
> **Goal:** become a counsellor who helps people make sense of what is going on in their heads and stand on their own feet.
> **Constraints:** must keep working · 3–5 hours/week · prefers listening, open to reading and video · wants validated sources.
> **Target:** self-study now → part-time MA Psychology (e.g. IGNOU, July 2027 intake) → supervised practice → NCAHP registration.

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> **How to read the notes.** The "Study notes" boxes are short summaries written for this roadmap, in plain words. They are *not* copied from the books. Each one ends with the link where you can read the original or a fuller explanation. Use them as a primer. The books and courses go much deeper.

1. The big picture

Which route, and why

Route	Path from a B.E.	Time to practise	Verdict
Psychiatrist	NEET-UG → MBBS (5.5 yrs) → NEET-PG → MD Psychiatry (3 yrs). Needs Class 12 Biology.	~10–11 yrs	Not your goal: you prefer talk-based work, not medication.
Clinical Psychologist (RCI)	4-yr psychology UG (or 3+1 bridge) → 2-yr MA Clinical Psychology (RCI)	~6–7 yrs	Means restarting undergrad.
Counselling Psychologist	MA/MSc Psychology (2 yrs, part-time possible) + supervised practice → NCAHP registration	**~2.5–3 yrs**	**Your route.**

Timeline at a glance

When	What
Nov 2026 – Jul 2027	Self-study (this roadmap). Volunteer or shadow if possible.
Jul 2027	Enrol in part-time MA Psychology (e.g. IGNOU MAPC). Keep UX job.
2027 – 2029	Degree + practicum + extra supervised hours; begin your own therapy.
~2029–30	Register with NCAHP; see clients part-time (evenings/weekends, online).
~2031–33	Shift to full-time counselling once practice income ≈ your salary.

The money picture

Item	Figure	Note
Your current salary	~₹8 LPA (~₹67k/month)	—
IGNOU MA Psychology fee	~₹10k/year, ~₹20–21k total	Aggregator figures; confirm on IGNOU portal.
Total transition cost (2–3 yrs)	~₹40k – ₹1 lakh	Rough estimate incl. books, supervision, own therapy.
Salaried counsellor, early career	~₹3–7 LPA (Payscale avg ~₹3.25 LPA)	Mid-career ~₹5–10 LPA.
Private practice per session	₹500–1,500 new · ₹2,000–3,500 experienced (metro)	Big variation by city.
Sessions/week to match ₹8 LPA	~17 at ₹1,000 · ~11 at ₹1,500	Over 48 working weeks.

> **Bottom line:** expect a dip for 1–2 years after qualifying. Avoid it by going **hybrid**: keep UX income, build a client base part-time, switch fully when the numbers match. UX/research roles at mental-health companies (e.g. Wysa, Amaha) are a strong bridge.

2. How to use this roadmap

Block	Time/week	When
🎧 Listening: podcast or audiobook	~2 hrs	Commute, chores, walks
🎬 Watching: one course module or lecture	~1 hr	One weekday evening
📖 Reading + notes	30–60 min	Weekend morning

The one habit that matters most: after each session, write 3 lines in a notebook. (1) one idea I learned, (2) where I saw it in my own life or work, (3) one question I still have. This turns passive listening into real learning, and the question list becomes gold when your degree starts.

Each phase lists more than you strictly need. If a week is busy, just do the listening block. Consistency beats volume.

3. Phase 1 (Months 1–3): Foundations

Goal: understand how the mind works, and what therapy actually looks like from the inside.

WATCH **Crash Course Psychology** (Hank Green, YouTube). Free. 40+ episodes of ~10 min covering the whole intro-psychology syllabus. Do 3–4 episodes a week.
youtube.com/playlist?list=PL8dPuuaLjXtOPRKzVLY0jJY-uHOH9KVU6 (if the link moves: search "Crash Course Psychology" on the Crash Course channel)

COURSE **The Science of Well-Being** (Prof. Laurie Santos, Yale · Coursera). Free to audit; certificate optional. ~10 weeks.
coursera.org/learn/the-science-of-well-being

COURSE · OPTIONAL **Introduction to Psychology** (Prof. Paul Bloom, Yale · Coursera). Free to audit. Take it if Crash Course leaves you wanting more depth.
coursera.org/learn/introduction-psychology

LISTEN **Hidden Brain** (Shankar Vedantam). Research-based stories on why we think and act as we do.
hiddenbrain.org

LISTEN **Speaking of Psychology** (American Psychological Association). Interviews with researchers; transcripts on the site.
apa.org/news/podcasts/speaking-of-psychology

AUDIOBOOK **Maybe You Should Talk to Someone** (Lori Gottlieb). A therapist writes about her clients and her own therapy. The best inside view of the job.
Available on Audible / Kindle / paperback in India.

Study notes 1.1: The six lenses of psychology

Psychology looks at the same behaviour through different "lenses". Knowing them helps you organise everything else you learn:

- **Biological:** brain, hormones, genes, sleep. *"Is this anxiety partly about sleep and caffeine?"*
- **Behavioural:** learning through rewards and consequences. *"What keeps this habit going?"*
- **Cognitive:** thoughts, beliefs, attention, memory. *"What is this person telling themselves?"*
- **Psychodynamic:** unconscious patterns, often rooted in early relationships. *"Where have I felt this before?"*
- **Humanistic:** growth, meaning, self-acceptance; the person as the expert on their life.
- **Socio-cultural:** family, community, culture, money, caste, gender. Especially important in India, where family expectations shape so much distress.

Good counsellors don't pick one lens. They ask which lenses explain this person's problem best.

Read more: Crash Course Psychology Ep. 1 (link above) · en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Psychology

Study notes 1.2: What the science of well-being says

- **Our "happiness forecasts" are often wrong.** We overestimate how much a raise, a gadget or a new city will change how we feel, because we adapt quickly (*hedonic adaptation*).
- **We compare against reference points**, not absolute amounts. That's why social media comparison hurts.
- **What reliably helps:** social connection, gratitude, helping others, exercise, sleep, being present (mindfulness), and spending time rather than money on experiences.
- **Knowing isn't doing** (Santos calls this the "G.I. Joe fallacy"). Change comes from practising habits, not just learning facts. Remember this when you work with clients too.

Source: The Science of Well-Being, Yale/Coursera (link above)

Study notes 1.3: What actually helps in therapy

Decades of research find that the **therapeutic alliance** (the trust and collaboration between counsellor and client) is one of the most consistent predictors of whether therapy helps, across almost all methods. This is good news for you: the alliance is built on listening, empathy and reliability, skills you already practise in user interviews.

Read more: en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Therapeutic_relationship

4. Phase 2 (Months 4–6): How counselling works

Goal: learn the core approaches and skills you will meet in your degree, so day one feels familiar.

READ **Feeling Good** (Dr David D. Burns). The classic, readable introduction to CBT, with exercises. Do the exercises on yourself.
Widely available in India (paperback/Kindle).

AUDIOBOOK / READ **The Gift of Therapy** (Dr Irvin Yalom). 85 short lessons on the craft from a master therapist. Easy to dip into.

READ · OPTIONAL **On Becoming a Person** (Carl Rogers). The founding text of person-centred counselling. Denser; read selected chapters.

FREE GUIDE **Psychological First Aid: Guide for Field Workers** (WHO, War Trauma Foundation, World Vision). The global standard for supporting someone in distress.
who.int/publications/i/item/9789241548205

FREE COURSE **Principles of Psychological First Aid** (International Medical Corps, DisasterReady). ~2 hrs, free, based on the WHO guide above.
disasterready.org/principles-of-psychological-first-aid

PREVIEW YOUR DEGREE **IGNOU MAPC material**. IGNOU publishes its course blocks free on eGyanKosh; search for "MPC-001" (Cognitive Psychology, Learning and Memory). Past papers and assignments show what's examined.
eGyanKosh: egyankosh.ac.in
MPC-001 assignment 2026–27: ignou.ac.in/viewFile/SOSS/assignments/MPC-001-26-27.pdf
MPC-001 question paper, June 2024: webservices.ignou.ac.in/…/June 2024/SOSS/MAPC/MPC-001.pdf

Study notes 2.1: The CBT model

Cognitive Behavioural Therapy rests on one idea: **it is not just events that upset us, but how we interpret them.** Thoughts, feelings and behaviours keep feeding each other:

Situation → Automatic thought → Feeling → Behaviour → (reinforces the thought)

Example: Manager doesn't reply to your message (situation) → "She thinks my work is bad" (thought) → anxiety (feeling) → you avoid her, over-work at night (behaviour) → less contact, more worry.

Common thinking traps (Burns calls them cognitive distortions):

Trap	What it sounds like
All-or-nothing	"If it's not perfect, it's a failure."
Overgeneralisation	"I *always* mess up presentations."
Mental filter	Dwelling on one criticism, ignoring ten compliments.
Discounting the positive	"They only praised me to be nice."
Mind reading / fortune telling	"He thinks I'm useless." / "This will go badly."
Catastrophising	"If I lose this job my life is over."
Emotional reasoning	"I feel stupid, so I must be stupid."
"Should" statements	"I should be further ahead by 28."
Labelling	"I'm a loser" instead of "I made a mistake."
Personalisation / blame	Taking all the blame, or putting it all on others.

Try it on yourself, a thought record: (1) situation, (2) feeling and intensity 0–100, (3) automatic thought, (4) which trap it fits, (5) evidence for / against, (6) a more balanced thought, (7) re-rate the feeling.

Source: *Feeling Good* (Burns) · en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cognitive_behavioral_therapy · en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cognitive_distortion

Study notes 2.2: Person-centred counselling (Carl Rogers)

Rogers argued that people grow on their own when the relationship offers three **core conditions**:

- **Empathy:** understanding the client's world as if from the inside, and showing that you understand.
- **Unconditional positive regard:** accepting the person fully, without judging, even when you don't agree with what they did.
- **Congruence (genuineness):** being real, not hiding behind a professional mask.

Most Indian counselling programmes teach this as the foundation for every other method. It also matches your own goal of helping people "stand on their own feet": in this approach the client, not the counsellor, is the expert on their life.

Source: *On Becoming a Person* (Rogers) · en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Person-centered_therapy

Study notes 2.3: Basic counselling micro-skills

These are the building blocks taught in every counselling skills module. Many will feel familiar from user interviews:

- **Attending:** open posture, appropriate eye contact, leaning in, calm presence. Gerard Egan's acronym is **SOLER**: Sit squarely, Open posture, Lean in, Eye contact, Relaxed.
- **Open questions:** "What was that like for you?" rather than "Were you upset?"
- **Paraphrasing:** restating the content in your own words.
- **Reflecting feelings:** "It sounds like you felt invisible in that meeting."
- **Summarising:** pulling threads together at the end of a topic or session.

- **Silence:** allowing pauses. Clients often say the most important thing after one.

Key difference from UX research: in user research you gather insight *for the product*. In counselling the insight belongs *to the client*. You help them see it; you don't hand it to them.

Source: Gerard Egan, *The Skilled Helper* (standard counselling-skills textbook)

Study notes 2.4: Psychological First Aid: Look, Listen, Link

The WHO guide organises support for someone in distress into three actions:

- **Look:** check for safety, urgent basic needs, and people showing serious distress.
- **Listen:** approach gently, ask about needs and concerns, listen, and help them feel calm.
- **Link:** help them meet basic needs, access information and services, and connect with loved ones and social support.

Don'ts: don't pressure people to tell their story, don't give false promises, don't judge, don't make decisions for them. PFA is *not* therapy. It's humane first support, which anyone can learn.

Source: WHO, *Psychological First Aid: Guide for Field Workers* (2011): who.int/publications/i/item/9789241548205

5. Phase 3 (Months 7–9): Your niche

Goal: build early depth in workplace counselling and digital-age wellbeing, where your design background is a real advantage.

A. Workplace wellbeing

LISTEN **WorkLife with Adam Grant** (TED Audio Collective). An organisational psychologist on how to make work not suck.
ted.com/podcasts/worklife (Adam Grant's newer show *ReThinking* is also on TED)

LISTEN **How's Work? with Esther Perel**. Real one-time sessions with coworkers and co-founders. A rare chance to hear a skilled therapist at work.
estherperel.com/podcast

READ **Burnout: The Secret to Unlocking the Stress Cycle** (Emily Nagoski & Amelia Nagoski). Practical and science-based.

REFERENCE **WHO: Burn-out an "occupational phenomenon"**. The official definition you'll use in corporate work.
who.int/news/item/28-05-2019-burn-out-an-occupational-phenomenon-…

Study notes 3.1: What burnout is (and isn't)

In ICD-11, the WHO describes burnout as a syndrome from **chronic workplace stress that has not been successfully managed**, with three dimensions:

1. Feelings of energy depletion or **exhaustion**
2. Increased **mental distance** from one's job, or negativism / cynicism about it
3. **Reduced professional efficacy**

Two things to remember: it refers **only to the work context**, and WHO classes it as an **occupational phenomenon, not a medical condition**. Burnout can overlap with depression, though, so a good counsellor screens for both.

Source: WHO news release, 28 May 2019 (link above) · en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Occupational_burnout

Study notes 3.2: The Job Demands–Resources (JD-R) model

A widely used research model for why work wears people down or energises them:

- **Job demands** (workload, time pressure, emotional demands, always-on messaging) drain energy, which leads toward **burnout**.
- **Job resources** (autonomy, supportive manager, feedback, growth, recognition) build motivation, which leads toward **engagement**.
- Resources **buffer** the effect of demands. High demands are tolerable when resources are high; high demands plus low resources is the danger zone.

Why it matters for you: corporate counselling isn't only helping individuals cope. It also helps organisations spot where demands outrun resources. That systems view is natural for a

designer.

Read more: en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Job_demands-resources_model

B. Digital-age wellbeing

LISTEN **Your Undivided Attention** (Center for Humane Technology: Tristan Harris, Aza Raskin). Technology, attention, AI and mental health, from former tech insiders. humanetech.com/podcast

READ **Dopamine Nation** (Dr Anna Lembke, Stanford psychiatrist). Compulsive overconsumption, including phones and social media, and how to reset.

READ **Digital Minimalism** (Cal Newport). A practical philosophy for using technology on purpose.

READ · CRITICALLY **The Anxious Generation** (Jonathan Haidt). Influential argument linking smartphones and youth mental health. Some researchers dispute the strength of the evidence, so read it alongside the critiques. Good practice for evaluating claims.

Study notes 3.3: Why apps are hard to put down (the psychology a designer knows)

- **Variable (intermittent) reinforcement:** rewards that arrive unpredictably (new likes, a new post when you pull to refresh) create the most persistent behaviour. B.F. Skinner showed this with slot-machine-like schedules.
- **The attention economy:** when a product is free, attention is what's being sold, so products are optimised to capture time.
- **Pleasure–pain balance:** Lembke describes how repeated quick pleasure is followed by a "rebound" of craving and low mood. A period of abstinence (she suggests about 30 days) can help reset.
- **Dark patterns:** design that steers users against their own interest: infinite scroll, autoplay, guilt-tripping opt-outs.

Your edge: you know these mechanisms from the inside. You can help clients see *how* their attention is being shaped, which removes self-blame ("I'm weak") and replaces it with strategy ("this is designed to hook me; here's how I redesign my environment").

Read more: en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Reinforcement · en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Attention_economy · en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dark_pattern · *Dopamine Nation* (Lembke)

6. Admission & regulation checklist

Study notes 6.1: The Indian regulatory landscape (as of Oct 2026)

- **Clinical psychologists** are licensed by the **Rehabilitation Council of India (RCI)**. RCI is replacing the M.Phil in Clinical Psychology with a 2-year MA Clinical Psychology (from 2025-26 / 2026-27 depending on source).
- **Counselling psychologists** now come under the **National Commission for Allied and Healthcare Professions (NCAHP)**. The 2026 registration regulations require registration, which is valid for 5 years with 15 hours/year of continuing professional development.
- **Open question:** how NCAHP treats distance-learning and 1-year master's degrees is still unclear. **Check this before you enrol.**
- **Mental Healthcare Act, 2017:** rights-based law covering access to care, confidentiality, advance directives, and the presumption that a suicide attempt is due to severe stress (effectively decriminalising it). Every practitioner in India should know it.

Sources: ncahp.abdm.gov.in · enrolment portal ahpr.abdm.gov.in/faq · Psychologs: NCAHP guidelines for psychology · CLEAR: India psychologist training · en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mental_Healthcare_Act,_2017

Before you apply (by May 2027)

✓	Task	Where
☐	Read the NCAHP notification: does a *distance / ODL* MA Psychology qualify for counselling psychologist registration?	ncahp.abdm.gov.in
☐	Confirm IGNOU MAPC fee, eligibility (any graduate) and July 2027 dates.	ignouadmission.samarth.edu.in
☐	Compare with one or two part-time/online UGC-entitled MA Psychology options, and check UGC entitlement.	University sites + UGC DEB list
☐	Talk to 2–3 practising counselling psychologists (LinkedIn, local clinics). Ask how they got supervised hours.	—
☐	Find a volunteer or shadowing opportunity (helplines, NGOs) to test the work.	e.g. iCall (TISS)
☐	Keep documents ready: degree certificate, marksheets, ID, photo.	—
☐	Plan the budget: ~₹10k/yr fees + set aside ~₹2–3k/month for books, supervision, own therapy.	—

Ethics reminder: until you are qualified and registered, don't describe what you offer as counselling or therapy. Peer support, coaching or "listening" is fine if clearly labelled. If you or anyone you talk to is in crisis, India's national tele-mental-health helpline **Tele-MANAS: 14416** (or 1-800-891-4416) is free and runs 24/7.

7. Progress tracker

✓	Month	Focus	Done when…
☐	1 (Nov 26)	Crash Course Ep. 1–14 · Hidden Brain (4 eps)	Notebook has 12+ entries
☐	2 (Dec 26)	Crash Course Ep. 15–28 · Science of Well-Being wks 1–4 · start Gottlieb audiobook	Tried one of the course's weekly "rewirement" habits for a week
☐	3 (Jan 27)	Crash Course Ep. 29–40 · Well-Being wks 5–10 · finish Gottlieb	Can explain the six lenses to a friend
☐	4 (Feb 27)	*Feeling Good* part 1 · Speaking of Psychology (4 eps)	3 thought records done on yourself
☐	5 (Mar 27)	*Feeling Good* part 2 · *Gift of Therapy* · PFA course	PFA certificate earned
☐	6 (Apr 27)	Rogers (selected chapters) · eGyanKosh MPC-001 preview · micro-skills practice	Practised reflective listening in 3 real conversations
☐	7 (May 27)	WorkLife + How's Work? · *Burnout* · JD-R model · **admission checklist**	NCAHP eligibility confirmed
☐	8 (Jun 27)	Your Undivided Attention · *Dopamine Nation* · **apply**	Application submitted
☐	9 (Jul 27)	*Digital Minimalism* · *Anxious Generation* (critically) · write "why I'm doing this" (1 page)	Enrolled 🎉

8. Sources used in this roadmap

Career, regulation and salary facts were gathered by web search in October 2026. Fee and salary figures come from aggregators and vary; always confirm on official sites.

- NCAHP rules: Careers360 · Psychologs · AHPR FAQ
- RCI / clinical psychology changes: CLEAR · UPS Education
- IGNOU MA Psychology fees: GetMyUni · Distance Education School
- MSc Counselling eligibility: Kristu Jayanti · St Aloysius · SJU
- Counsellor pay: Payscale (early career) · Payscale (mid career) · TherapyRoute India · SVYASA
- UX pay: Instahyre · Product Leadership
- NEET age limit removed: Medical Dialogues
- Burnout definition: WHO